XII—Brotherhood of Man

> ‘He also had this bad habit: while one of his questions was being answered, he would suddenly, and before there had been time to deal with it, ask another. He had not the patience to hear one explanation at a time but in his eagerness for knowledge, tried to learn everything at once, like a hungry man trying to swallow his food at a single gulp.’
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> – The Jesuit Fathers, *Akbar and the Jesuits*

That Humayun’s brothers loom as large in history as the padishah himself while Akbar’s brother is entirely forgotten says as much about the two emperors as it does about how history is written. As Munis Faruqui points out in his aptly titled essay, ‘The Forgotten Prince’, three currents of historiography have come together to sink Muhammad Hakim in the ditch of obscurity.

First, there was Akbar’s propaganda, via Abul Fazl, characterizing his half-brother as a ‘dim-witted, self-serving, and cowardly but obdurate political gadfly’; followed by colonial writings in which Hakim appears as a ‘narrow-minded Muslim bigot . . . a foil against which to better appreciate Akbar’s tolerance’; and finally, the unfortunate mirza’s ‘multiple identities as a Kabul-based, orthodox-Muslim, Persian-speaking, ethnic-Turk’ made of him an ungainly square peg in the round hole of nationalist narratives written in the twentieth century.[1]

And yet, as Faruqui demonstrates, Hakim posed a serious challenge to Akbar while he lived, and did so far more cleverly than he is given credit for. In brief, while Akbar embodied the ideal man become all-powerful emperor, exercising his God-given right to rule for the betterment of his people, Hakim adopted the persona of the adventurer – and not of just any adventurer, but of the most adventurous man in the two brothers’ family, their grandfather Babur.

‘Like Babur’, writes Faruqui, Hakim, ‘actively embraced a rough-and-ready Turkish-steppe identity’. In equal parts ghazi, Islamic warrior, and avid gardener; as much a ‘bold risk-taker’ (marching upon Lahore in the 1560s while on the run from Sulaiman and Haram) as a generous companion, ‘carousing with friends . . . in the hills above Kabul’. The most critical play in this competition of personas between Akbar and Hakim,